

Video game therapy - a new frontier

GAMERS REJOICE! THERE'S a new rationalization for your habit—it's therapeutic!

Doctors pronounced Ethan Myers brain dead after a car accident dealt the 9-year-old a severe brain injury in 2002. After he miraculously awoke from a nearly month-long coma, doctors declared he would never again eat on his own, walk or talk. Yet, thanks partly to a video game system, Myers has caught up with his peers in school and even read a speech to a large group of students.

"I'm doing the exact same things as them. I'm getting buddies and stuff," said Myers, who had relearned to walk and was reading at a second-grade level before his video game therapy began in May 2004.

"I couldn't remember where I put stuff and now I can. I remember school stuff and people's names," he said in a telephone interview from his family's home in Colorado.

More fundamentally, Myers can now fully open his right hand, which paralysis had curled closed. His brother and sister, who were in the car with him during the accident and each suffered mild brain injuries, have also shown improvement in their memory and other functions.

Ethan and his parents attribute his most recent progress to



Neurofeedback is a form of conditioning that rewards people for producing specific brain waves, such as those that appear when a person is relaxed or paying attention.

While this form of treatment has been around for decades, incorporating video games marks a new frontier that taps young people's fascination with animation and electronics to sweeten often frightening, lengthy and tedious medical treatments.

Video games are being used, for instance, to help sick children manage pain and anxiety during hospital stays.

A young leukemia patient inspired "Ben's Game," which let him fight the cancer cells invading his body. A private island called Brigadoon in Linden Lab's "Second Life" virtual world is open only to people with Asperger's syndrome and autism.

West Virginia's public schools are battling obesity by making "Dance Dance Revolution"—a step-to-the-beat video game—part of their curriculum, while Nintendo has made a splash with its new "Brain Age" mind-exercising game

For the complete column, visit http://news.com.com/Video+game+therapy--a+new+frontier/2100-1043_3-6051269.html?tag=nefd.top

Vista Sucks, No It Doesn't, Yes It Does...

THE ONGOING BATTLE—Will Windows Vista really change our lives? Will it turn our PCs into blubbery masses of nothing? ExtremeTech's Jason Cross muses again.

Thanks in large part to the title, my article called Why Windows Vista Won't Suck got linked to all over the interweb. Of course, five minutes has now passed and the whole world has moved on, updating their blogs furiously with numerous posts about Microsoft's Origami project and more "news" about how the PlayStation 3 won't ship this Spring. Ah, the attention span of the 'net.

I wanted to spend a little time in my editorial column this week addressing some of the comments and emails I received about the feature. And boy, did I get an earful.

Certainly, response was varied. In our own forum, responses ranged from (and I'm paraphrasing here), "Hey, thanks for the great article, I didn't know Vista had such sweeping changes" to "You're just a Microsoft shill and you love DRM and you should die painfully and slowly." To those who found some value in the feature, I'm glad you liked it. To those that didn't, I'm glad you read it anyway, and I hope you just keep an open mind about all software and hardware products—from Microsoft and any other vendors.

Am I a Microsoft shill? No, of course not. Boy, having Microsoft Shill money would be sweet! I bet they pay shills a lot over in Redmond. If I were a shill for Microsoft, paid or unpaid, I doubt I would have had such negative things to say about their digital media initiatives in my column about switching to iPod. That one generated a very concerned phone call from the Windows Media Player team at Microsoft, as a matter of fact. I told them, in effect, to "put up or shut up." I want to see how they're going to compete with iTunes/iPod. I gave Microsoft latest and greatest Laser Mouse 6000 a whopping score of 3, because hey, I think it sucks. We call 'em like we see 'em over here at ExtremeTech, and we go out of our way not to let ourselves be influenced by any corporation.

All I ask is that you bear in mind what the article was all about. I thought the title, description, and introduction made it pretty clear: The feature was a description of the ways in which Vista will be more than just another Windows ME. It was a "Here's why this is a major update" thing. It's not a review, and is in no way meant to catalog all the positive and negative aspects of the upcoming OS. Frankly, it's way too early for that. We'll be sure to let you know what faults we find in the OS when it's complete enough. Just to be fair, when Steven J. Vaughan-Nichols over at our sister site DesktopLinux.com wrote a rebuttal called Why Windows Vista Will Suck, we copied over his intro, pointed to the article on his site, and put it up front and center on the ExtremeTech homepage.

There seems to be some really grave concerns and misunderstandings about the DRM in Vista. Quite a few readers seemed to think that Vista will ship with an amazing, unprecedented amount of DRM, which will prohibit them from doing all the fun non-DRM stuff they enjoy today. This just really isn't true.

<http://www.extremetech.com/article2/0,1697,1936059,00.asp>

